

THE TRAVELS OF A SADHU IN THE HIMALAYAS
By Jaladhar Sen
Translated by Somdatta Mandal
SPEAKING TIGER
₹499; 264 pages

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In Search of the Sublime

A 19th-century travelogue offers a meditative glimpse into an era when pilgrimage to the high Himalayas was a journey of the soul

OF ALL IMAGES KNOWN TO MAN, THERE IS NONE MORE POWERFUL AND POIGNANT than that of an individual embarking on a quest, battling the elements in the mountains. And therefore the surfeit of literature on mountain pilgrimage. But, in the Uttarakhand Himalayas, a region that has attracted pilgrims since times immemorial, one finds very few genuine travel accounts that can give us a peek into the past. After the devastating 2013 floods in Kedarnath, I began searching for old maps and literature on ancient pilgrim routes that could be mapped as future rescue pathways. I found few authentic accounts and maps in Hindi and English. The walking routes had faded from public memory too. However, digging deeper, I unearthed a wealth of material in the vernacular—Bengali, Tamil, Maithili, Telugu, even French.

Jaladhar Sen's *The Travels of a Sadhu in the Himalayas* (translated from Bengali by Somdatta Mandal), an account of his travels in the Badrikashram region, describes the pilgrimage in the 1890s. The work is significant as it allows us to understand how the Himalayan pilgrimage has transformed—from being an exercise in just being there frugally, moving body and mind, waiting for the next experience to present itself, to its current status of commercialised holiday.

To my mind, the book is special in two ways. Firstly, it narrates the travel journey not from the point of view of an over-enthusiastically devout pilgrim, but presents the experiences of a *paribrajak* sadhu, a secular sojourner. What also makes the book special is that the translator manages to tread the thin line between over-simplification and over-explanation. And therefore, while it amusingly retains all the prejudices of a Bengali struggling to survive the mountains, it also presents a deeply reflective experience of being overwhelmed by the natural splendour of the Upper Ganga region.

This is a book that describes a truly sublime and transformative experience, that starts out as an escape from reality but eventually becomes a release from illusion. ■

—Lokesh Ohri

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Posture Politics

In *Fascist Yoga*, Stewart Home challenges modern yoga's sanctity, tracing its roots to European nationalism

Swami Vivekananda, one of yoga's great proponents, looked down upon what is today its most popular incarnation—*asanas*, or the postures one strikes for better health. He thought them fit only for "sorcerers, fakirs and *jogis*", writes historian Meera Nanda in a 2011 piece cited in Stewart Home's *Fascist Yoga*, a recent book arguing that yoga's spiritual aspects—traceable at least to the 2,000-year-old texts by Patanjali—have nothing to do with its physical ones. Historians say that the origin is just 100 years old, when white journalists, religious leaders and military men started using "orientalist fairy dust" to legitimise Aryan supremacy through what were essentially very European gymnastics.

Home's book mentions several proponents of this 'eastern' wisdom who influenced—or were directly enrolled with—the Nazis, the Iron Guard or Mussolini's fascists. While the book lacks narrative and reads like a leaden 'Yoga's Top 10 Villains' list, Home traces well their lineage down to modern-day conservatives like Donald Trump, Steve Bannon, Andrew Tate and Alex Jones.



FASCIST YOGA
Grifters, Occultists, White Supremacists, and the New Order In Wellness
By Stewart Home
NAVAYANA
₹499; 224 pages

Today, you find anti-vaccine rhetoric, disdain for left-wing politics and appeals to harness an "inner masculinity" across yoga centres in the West—not to mention a litany of sex offences.

"'Scientific' studies of yoga...merely demonstrate that exercise is good for you, rather than proving yoga is a superior form of exercise," writes Home. Fewer rants and repetitions would have helped, but the book's academic rigour justifies its raison d'être: proving yoga is multicultural now and no longer essentially Hindu or Indian, with a history that's neither as harmless nor holy as often portrayed. ■

—Udbhav Seth